

PHP Geek, FOSS Enthusiast, CTO and a Paediatrician

‘PHP geek, free and open source software enthusiast, CTO (chief technical officer) of SANIssoft’ — that’s how Dr Tarique Sani likes to describe himself. He’s qualified to be a paediatrician, but his love for open source has turned him into a geek for the past two decades and more. He recalls the good old days...

Dr Tarique Sani was educated as a medical doctor but diversified into open source software development and services, particularly PHP, and has been successfully running a company for more than two decades. Swati, his wife and co-traveller in the FOSS (free and open source) journey, is a mass communications professional who “wholeheartedly supported me in this journey by providing all the logistics and running the business side of things.” When we met in Goa recently, she recalled her love for Urdu poetry, an interest she shared with Dr Sani’s mother.

The projects Dr Sani has been involved with and has contributed to include WAPpop (pop mail client phones); Aaina-e-ghazal (trilingual dictionary for Urdu ghazal fans); NagpurBirds (atlas of birds from Nagpur district); Coppermine Picture Gallery (CMS for photos); and *phplib* (utility library for PHP).

But that was a long time back, when GNU/Linux was just getting known in India in the mid- to late 1990s. Looking back, he says the highpoints of his memories of the last two decades are “that most friendships and relations forged during that time have lasted till date.”

How did he first get started?

Says Dr Sani: “Living in Nagpur, I connected with folks from Bangalore via a BBS [Bulletin Board Service, the pre-internet slow way of communicating across copper-wire connected phones]. I had just installed Linux on my



Dr Tarique and his wife Swati Sani

computer. A chance question by Krishna Kumar, then editor of PCQuest, about GIMP, led to Swati writing a review in the magazine.”

Most readers of this magazine would know this, but you might be one of those not into graphics and processing images (photos). GIMP, or the GNU Image Manipulation Program, is still going strong. It is a free and open source software (FOSS) raster graphics editor. GIMP is used for image manipulation (retouching) and image editing, free-form drawing, saving in different image file formats, and other tasks. Plugins can be used to extend it, and GIMP is

scriptable. Some artists use it for drawing, though it was not made for this purpose.

So, how did his involvement with GNU/Linux grow?

“Atul Chitnis, the late noted FOSS campaigner and prominent event organiser, who also wrote a lot on the topic, wanted to meet us. We travelled to Bangalore and met him and the rest of the Linux-Bangalore team. We progressively got involved with organising a series of conferences which ultimately became FOSS.IN,” says Dr Sani.

Both Linux-Bangalore and FOSS.IN were community events organised in the city then called Bangalore, which attracted geeks and community members from across India.

“Along the way, our own software company, which was doing PHP based development, grew. I wrote about PHP for a book for Wrox Press (Professional PHP4, 2002) and got involved with several open source projects,” he says.